

MARKET ANALYSIS

Maroa Park Sale: The Fresno Multifamily Bid Is Real, but Narrow

A \$44 million trade shows capital is available for the right basis, not for every asset.

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A source-grounded Light Tower Insight. The complete note follows.

A credit committee reviewing a \$44 million multifamily loan in Fresno has a question that no broker pitch deck answers cleanly: Is this trade evidence of a market, or evidence of a single buyer who needed a specific basis?

The answer determines whether the deal is a comp or a curiosity.

JBT Property Management sold Maroa Park Apartments, a 248-unit property at 475-585 W. Sierra Ave., to an unnamed private buyer. The price works out to roughly \$177,400 per unit. The Mogharebi Group represented the seller. That is the situation.

The story is that a private buyer was willing to underwrite Fresno multifamily at a basis that a larger institutional platform likely would not touch. The question for the market is whether that basis is repeatable.

Fresno is not a gateway market. It is a Central Valley city with a growing population, a logistics-adjacent economy, and a housing supply that has not kept pace with demand. Those are structural tailwinds. But the city also sits in a state where rent control, tenant protection laws, and rising property taxes compress net operating income growth. A buyer underwriting Fresno today is betting that local rent growth outpaces cost inflation, not that the market suddenly re-rates upward.

The per-unit price of \$177,400 is below replacement cost for new construction in the region, which typically runs above \$300,000 per unit. That gap is the buyer's margin of safety. It is also the seller's concession. JBT Property Management did not sell because it lost faith in Fresno. It sold because the bid it received was high enough to exit, and the alternative was holding through a period where interest rates make leverage expensive and exit optionality uncertain.

Private capital is the marginal buyer in this kind of trade. Institutional capital, which dominated multifamily acquisitions from 2019 through 2022, has largely stepped back from secondary markets unless the basis offers a double-digit discount to peak pricing. Private buyers have lower cost-of-capital requirements, longer hold periods, and less pressure to mark assets to market. They can underwrite to a 5 percent going-in cap rate where an institution needs 6.5 percent to clear its hurdle.

That difference is what made this deal possible.

The lender who finances this acquisition faces a different calculation. The loan will likely be smaller relative to value than a 2021-era origination, because the buyer is putting more equity in to hit the basis. That lower leverage is the lender's protection. But the lender is also underwriting a market where comparable sales are thin, rent growth is uncertain, and the exit is five to seven years away. The loan is not a vote of confidence in Fresno. It is a risk-allocation choice: the lender is betting that the buyer's equity cushion and operating discipline absorb the downside before the debt does.

What the market should test next is whether other private buyers step into similar trades at similar bases. One deal does not make a trend. But if a second or third Fresno multifamily trade clears in the next six months at a per-unit price between \$170,000 and \$185,000, the market will have established a floor. That floor would be meaningful for owners who bought between 2019 and 2022 at prices above \$200,000 per unit. They would face a basis gap that only time and rent growth can close.

The Mogharebi Group's involvement is worth noting. The firm specializes in multifamily sales in Western markets and has a track record of matching private capital with secondary-market assets. Its ability to find a buyer for Maroa Park suggests that the bid for well-located, stabilized multifamily in Fresno is real, but narrow. It is not a signal that capital is flooding back into the Central Valley. It is a signal that capital is available for the right basis, the right sponsor, and the right asset quality.

For owners in Fresno and similar secondary markets, the lesson is uncomfortable but clear: liquidity exists, but only at a price that acknowledges the current cost of capital. The bid is not gone. It is just lower than the last trade. The question is whether that lower bid is the new normal or a temporary discount that sellers can wait out.

The answer will come from the next trade, not this one.

SOURCES

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